PUGET SOUND ENERGY • DOCUMENTATION QUALITY ASSURANCE

Technical Writing Review Checklist

Document Number	QA-CL-001	**Version**	1.0
Applies To	New documents and material revisions	**Function**	Documentation Quality Assurance

A structured quality assurance tool for validating documents prior to approval. Use the checklist on every new document and on any revision that materially changes content. Mark each item Pass when satisfied, Fail when a defect is identified, or N/A when the item does not apply. Do not approve a document until all applicable items are satisfied or the exceptions are formally accepted.

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How to Use

1. Complete the Document Identification block below.
2. Work through each section in order. Sections build on one another — structure first, then clarity, then formatting, and finally compliance.
3. Record the result for every item: Pass, Fail, or N/A.
4. Document any failures with a specific page or section reference and a recommended correction. For N/A, provide a one-line justification.
5. Complete the Review Summary & Sign-off at the end of the checklist.

Document Identification

Document Title	*[Title of the document under review]*
Document Number	*[SOP-XXX-000]*
Version	*[Version]*
Document Owner	*[Name / Title]*
Reviewer	*[Name / Title]*
Review Date	*[MM-DD-YYYY]*

> **RESULT KEY** **Pass** — item meets the standard. **Fail** — defect identified; record details in the Notes column. **N/A** — item does not apply; provide a one-line justification.

1 Required SOP Sections

Confirm that all required document components are present, in the correct order, and complete. Use this section first; if components are missing, return the document to the author before reviewing further.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
1.1	Title page is present and identifies the document number, version, and effective date.	☐	☐	☐	
1.2	Purpose section is present and clearly states the business need or operational driver.	☐	☐	☐	
1.3	Scope section is present and identifies what is in scope and the personnel and/or locations to which it applies.	☐	☐	☐	
1.4	Definitions, terms, and acronyms are presented in table form and cover every specialized term used.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
1.5	Roles and responsibilities are listed by role title (not individual name) with clear responsibilities for each.	☐	☐	☐	
1.6	Procedure/methodology section contains complete, ordered steps with prerequisites identified.	☐	☐	☐	
1.7	References section lists all internal and external sources cited or relied upon.	☐	☐	☐	
1.8	Revision history table is present with at least the initial release entry.	☐	☐	☐	
1.9	All required appendices are included, titled, and referenced from the body of the document.	☐	☐	☐	
1.10	Table of contents is present and accurate for documents longer than five pages.	☐	☐	☐	

2 Structure and Organization

Verify that information is organized so that readers can find what they need quickly and follow the flow of the document without rereading.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
2.1	Content is organized from general to specific within each section.	☐	☐	☐	
2.2	Section numbering is sequential and consistent (1, 1.1, 1.1.1) with no gaps or restarts.	☐	☐	☐	
2.3	Heading hierarchy is logical and limited to three levels in most cases.	☐	☐	☐	
2.4	Each section contains only material relevant to its title.	☐	☐	☐	
2.5	Related material is grouped together; unrelated material is separated.	☐	☐	☐	
2.6	No section is empty or contains only a placeholder where final content is required.	☐	☐	☐	
2.7	Cross-references to other sections, figures, tables, and documents are accurate and use the correct identifier.	☐	☐	☐	
2.8	Procedure steps appear in the order they are performed.	☐	☐	☐	
2.9	Decision points and exception handling are placed near the steps they affect.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
2.10	Supporting reference material is placed in appendices, not interleaved with primary content.	☐	☐	☐	
2.11	Page breaks are placed so that headings do not appear orphaned at the bottom of a page.	☐	☐	☐	

3 Clarity and Readability

Confirm that the document communicates clearly to its intended audience using plain, direct language.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
3.1	Audience is identified and the level of detail is appropriate to that audience.	☐	☐	☐	
3.2	Sentences are short and direct; the average sentence is 15–25 words.	☐	☐	☐	
3.3	Each sentence expresses no more than two ideas.	☐	☐	☐	
3.4	Paragraphs are short and focused on a single topic; long paragraphs have been broken up.	☐	☐	☐	
3.5	Plain words are used in place of jargon and complex synonyms (e.g., “use” not “utilize”).	☐	☐	☐	
3.6	Filler phrases have been eliminated (e.g., “in order to,” “due to the fact that,” “at this point in time”).	☐	☐	☐	
3.7	Hedge words and qualifiers have been removed unless they convey a specific meaning.	☐	☐	☐	
3.8	Ambiguous pronouns and unclear antecedents have been replaced with explicit nouns.	☐	☐	☐	
3.9	Examples, analogies, or callouts are used where they aid comprehension.	☐	☐	☐	
3.10	Document is readable on first pass without requiring readers to backtrack.	☐	☐	☐	
3.11	Document scans well — a reader can locate key information by skimming headings, lists, and tables.	☐	☐	☐	

4 Tone and Style

Confirm the document's tone and voice match the standards in the Technical Writing Style Guide.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
4.1	Tone is professional, neutral, and objective throughout.	☐	☐	☐	
4.2	Active voice is used by default where appropriate.	☐	☐	☐	
4.3	Passive voice is used only where the actor is unknown, irrelevant, or the action is the focus.	☐	☐	☐	
4.4	Imperative voice is used for procedure steps; each step starts with an action verb.	☐	☐	☐	
4.5	Mandatory actions use "must," "shall," or "will"; recommended actions use "should."	☐	☐	☐	
4.6	Document does not address the reader inconsistently (e.g., switching between "you," "the user," and "the operator").	☐	☐	☐	
4.7	Document does not contain unnecessary disclaimers, apologies, or hedging.	☐	☐	☐	
4.8	Tone is appropriate for the audience and matches the document's formality level (operational document vs. policy vs. training).	☐	☐	☐	

5 Formatting and Visual Design

Verify the document follows the formatting conventions defined in the style guide. Formatting issues are common and easy to overlook — check this section carefully.

5.1 Headings and Body Text

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.1.1	Built-in heading styles (Heading 1, Heading 2, Heading 3) are used; headings are not manually formatted. This also enables screen-reader and navigation-pane support.	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.2	Heading capitalization is consistent throughout (sentence case OR title case, not both).	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.3	Headings are short, descriptive, and parallel in grammatical structure.	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.4	Body font is the approved typeface (Calibri 11 pt).	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.1.5	Line spacing is at least 1.08 in body text.	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.6	Paragraph spacing is consistent across the document.	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.7	Page margins are 1 inch on all sides.	☐	☐	☐	
5.1.8	Page orientation is correct for the content (portrait by default; landscape only for wide tables/diagrams).	☐	☐	☐	

5.2 Lists

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.2.1	Bulleted lists are used for unordered items; numbered and alphabetical lists are used where sequence matters.	☐	☐	☐	
5.2.2	Every list is introduced with a complete lead-in sentence ending in a colon.	☐	☐	☐	
5.2.3	List items are parallel in grammatical form (all noun phrases, all imperative verbs, or all complete sentences).	☐	☐	☐	
5.2.4	Lists are at least two items long.	☐	☐	☐	
5.2.5	List numbering is continuous and does not restart unintentionally.	☐	☐	☐	
5.2.6	Procedure step numbering is correct, sequential, and not reset across sub-sections.	☐	☐	☐	

5.3 Tables and Figures

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.3.1	Every table has a number and a descriptive title.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.2	Table header rows are bold and shaded for visual distinction.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.3	Table cell content is concise; long explanations have been moved to body text.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.4	Bullet items in tables share grammatical form column by column.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.5	Numbers within columns are right-aligned or aligned at the decimal point.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.3.6	Tables that span multiple pages repeat the header row.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.7	Every figure has a number and a descriptive caption.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.8	Every figure is referenced in the body text by its number.	☐	☐	☐	
5.3.9	Figures are legible at the document's normal viewing size and print size.	☐	☐	☐	

5.4 Emphasis and White Space

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.4.1	Italics are used for document titles, defined terms on first use, and instructional placeholders only.	☐	☐	☐	
5.4.2	Underlining is reserved for hyperlinks.	☐	☐	☐	
5.4.3	Pages are not crowded; sections are separated by adequate white space.	☐	☐	☐	

5.5 Header and Footer

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
5.5.1	Header includes the company logo.	☐	☐	☐	
5.5.2	Footer includes the version number, page number, and document number.	☐	☐	☐	
5.5.3	Header and footer appear consistently on all body pages.	☐	☐	☐	
5.5.4	Page numbering is set to auto-update.	☐	☐	☐	

6 Consistency

Verify that the document uses consistent terminology, naming, capitalization, and formatting throughout. Inconsistencies undermine reader confidence and frequently cause operational errors.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
6.1	One term is used for one concept throughout (e.g., "operator," not alternating with "user" or "technician").	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
6.2	Terminology matches the Terms and Acronyms Section.	☐	☐	☐	
6.3	Document, system, equipment, and form names use their official names — no nicknames or informal abbreviations.	☐	☐	☐	
6.4	Capitalization of named systems and proper nouns is consistent.	☐	☐	☐	
6.5	Generic (common) nouns are not capitalized for emphasis; capitalization is reserved for proper nouns and defined terms.	☐	☐	☐	
6.6	Role descriptions in the Roles & Responsibilities section share a consistent structure.	☐	☐	☐	
6.7	Date format is consistent (e.g., MM-DD-YYYY for operational records).	☐	☐	☐	
6.8	Time format is consistent (24-hour HH:MM in operational documents).	☐	☐	☐	
6.9	Number-and-unit formatting is consistent (numerals with units; non-breaking space between).	☐	☐	☐	
6.10	Cross-reference style is consistent (e.g., “Section 6.2” not “section 6.2”).	☐	☐	☐	
6.11	Bullet and numbering styles are uniform across all lists.	☐	☐	☐	

7 Procedural Accuracy and Completeness

This is the highest-stakes review section. An unclear or incomplete procedure step can result in a safety incident, a regulatory finding, or a costly error. Validate procedural content with the SME(s) responsible for the work.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
7.1	Each step contains only one action in most cases.	☐	☐	☐	
7.2	Steps are numbered sequentially with sub-steps using lowercase letters and Roman numerals as needed.	☐	☐	☐	
7.3	The actor is identified for each step when multiple roles are involved.	☐	☐	☐	
7.4	Prerequisites are stated before the procedure begins.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
7.5	Decision points use clear conditional language ("If… then… otherwise…").	☐	☐	☐	
7.6	Complex branching logic uses a flow diagram or decision table rather than nested prose.	☐	☐	☐	
7.7	Expected results, verifications, or checkpoints are stated where applicable.	☐	☐	☐	
7.8	The procedure has been validated end-to-end against the actual work — no missing or out-of-order steps.	☐	☐	☐	
7.9	All exceptions, escalations, and abnormal conditions are addressed.	☐	☐	☐	
7.10	All records produced by the procedure are listed with storage location.	☐	☐	☐	
7.11	Closeout activities (notifications, documentation, handoffs) are included.	☐	☐	☐	
7.12	The procedure can be executed by the intended audience without additional verbal explanation.	☐	☐	☐	

8 Terminology and Acronyms

Verify that specialized terminology and acronyms are correctly defined and used.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
8.1	Every acronym is spelled out on first use (outside of the Defined Acronyms table), with the acronym in parentheses.	☐	☐	☐	
8.2	After first use, the acronym alone is used for the rest of the document.	☐	☐	☐	
8.3	All acronyms used in the document appear in the Defined Acronyms table.	☐	☐	☐	
8.4	Acronyms in headings are spelled out somewhere on the same page.	☐	☐	☐	
8.5	Plurals of acronyms use lowercase "s" with no apostrophe (SOPs, IMTs).	☐	☐	☐	
8.6	Possessives of acronyms use apostrophe-s (the IMT's response).	☐	☐	☐	
8.7	Defined terms are used consistently and not interchanged with synonyms.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
8.8	Each definition is concise, plain-language, and does not use the term within its own definition.	☐	☐	☐	
8.9	Terms and Acronyms tables are alphabetized for ease of reference.	☐	☐	☐	

9 Grammar, Punctuation, and Mechanics

Confirm that grammar, spelling, and punctuation conform to the style guide and standard professional usage.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
9.1	Document has been spell-checked, including domain-specific terms verified against authoritative sources.	☐	☐	☐	
9.2	No typographical errors (transposed letters, doubled words, missing words).	☐	☐	☐	
9.3	Subject-verb agreement is correct, including with collective nouns.	☐	☐	☐	
9.4	Tenses are consistent within sections; shifts in tense are intentional and clear.	☐	☐	☐	
9.5	Modifiers are placed next to the words they modify; no dangling or misplaced modifiers.	☐	☐	☐	
9.6	Items in a series within a sentence are parallel (e.g., “fast, accurate, and reversible”).	☐	☐	☐	
9.7	Serial (Oxford) commas are used in lists of three or more.	☐	☐	☐	
9.8	Single space follows each period.	☐	☐	☐	
9.9	Semicolons, colons, em dashes, and en dashes are used correctly.	☐	☐	☐	
9.10	Quotation marks are consistent (smart or straight, not mixed).	☐	☐	☐	
9.11	Apostrophes are used correctly for contractions and possessives; “its” and “it’s” are not confused.	☐	☐	☐	
9.12	Commonly confused words are used correctly (affect/effect, less/fewer, ensure/insure/assure, comprise/compose).	☐	☐	☐	
9.13	Numbers below 10 are spelled out except when paired with a unit; numerals are used for 10 and above.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
9.14	ALL CAPS is reserved for short labels (e.g., WARNING) and not used for body text or headings.	☐	☐	☐	

10 Accessibility

Confirm that the document is accessible to readers with a range of abilities, devices, and contexts.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
10.1	Color is not the only means of conveying information.	☐	☐	☐	
10.2	Every figure includes alt text that describes its meaning, not just its appearance.	☐	☐	☐	
10.3	Charts and diagrams are accompanied by a text description.	☐	☐	☐	
10.4	Tables include marked header rows so they are recognized by assistive technology.	☐	☐	☐	
10.5	Reading order is logical when the document is consumed linearly (no floating text boxes that break flow).	☐	☐	☐	
10.6	Hyperlinks are descriptive (e.g., “Refer to the Wildfire Risk Management Plan”) rather than “click here.”	☐	☐	☐	

11 Document Control and Compliance

Confirm the document complies with document control requirements and organizational policies.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
11.1	Document number follows the organizational naming convention.	☐	☐	☐	
11.2	Version number is correct and follows the versioning standard.	☐	☐	☐	
11.3	Effective date is set or scheduled appropriately.	☐	☐	☐	
11.4	Revision history is complete and lists every prior version.	☐	☐	☐	
11.5	Description of changes for the current revision is specific and auditable (no “various updates”).	☐	☐	☐	
11.6	All required approval signatures are in place before publication.	☐	☐	☐	

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
11.7	Document supersedes the prior version cleanly; the superseded version is archived per policy.	☐	☐	☐	
11.8	All hyperlinks resolve and point to the correct destination.	☐	☐	☐	
11.9	All internal cross-references are hyperlinked.	☐	☐	☐	
11.10	All external references are current and authoritative.	☐	☐	☐	

12 Final Verification

Complete this final verification before recommending the document for approval.

#	Review Item	Pass	Fail	N/A	Notes / Reference
12.1	All open comments and tracked changes have been resolved.	☐	☐	☐	
12.2	Document has been reviewed by the appropriate subject matter expert(s).	☐	☐	☐	
12.3	Document is ready for circulation to approvers.	☐	☐	☐	

Review Summary & Sign-off

Overall Result	☐ Approved for circulation ☐ Approved with minor corrections ☐ Returned to author
Items Failed	
Items Marked N/A	
Summary of Required Corrections	

Role	Name / Title	Signature	Date
Reviewer			
Document Owner			
Approver			